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How to Eat Cat Food with Dignity

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How to Eat Cat Food with Dignity

A Dramatic Interpretation (Male/Female)

By Clint Snyder

JAIME

You look like a nice person, someone that would never judge me too harshly, so I'll tell you a secret. It's a little embarrassing, so you have to promise not to laugh… I ate cat food for breakfast for a whole month one time. Bet you weren't expecting that, huh? I bet you thought "Oh, they probably eat a pint of ice cream every night and bawl their eyes out to some sappy vampire teen angst movie." Nope. Cat food. And it wasn't fancy feast either, it was the cheap kind and in case you were wondering, yes, there is a difference in taste.

I walked into the kitchen one morning and I saw it there on the plate. I stared at it for a minute or two, then my dad said, "Go ahead, and eat your breakfast." I wasn't exactly sure what it was at first, and then it hit me…

My Dad had lost his job about six months ago and we had been struggling ever since. Eating ramen, spaghetti-Os and canned food from the church, but they had been low lately and last time we showed up they didn't have anything for us. We didn't have any family we could rely on and my mom has passed a few years back. Thankfully my parents were able to pay off the house before it happened. She had been sick for a long time and the medical bills almost wiped them out before all this. That was it. I was just me, my stupid brother, my stupid father and this big stupid empty house. Oh, and the cat food that reeked.

(Sticks out toungue in disgust.) My dad must have saw me because he got defensive… He always talks a lot when he gets uncomfortable. "Well, yeah… it's

cheaper than regular food and it tastes just the same. Back in the army we ate all kinds of things, rats, dogs, whatever we could find. Besides, Fred seems to like it." I'm not eating it. This is humiliating and if mom were still here… if mom were still here she wouldn't make us." "I said sit down and eat." (Stern.) That was harsh for him. It caught me off guard, so I sat down and surrendered myself to the lumpy oozing meat perfectly shaped to the can it came from. It tasted surprisingly bland, like a little bit of bad tuna mixed in with a lot of sawdust or wet chalk. After the first couple bites it stops tasting like anything, then it went down a lot easier.

My brother Fred likes to be called Freddie. He has been Freddie the past three Halloweens in a row and not just because we can't afford a new costume. He really likes it. Nightmare on Elm Street is his favorite movie, which may be strange for a seven year old, but Fred is imaginative and according to him that's the best thing to be. He likes Freddie's ability to punish wrongdoers of the town, or as he likes to put it, "I like to stab bad guys." (High-Pitched.) And while most people might find Freddie to be that bad guy, he only seems to kill lazy teenagers that lie around the house drinking, doing drugs and sleeping too much and besides as my brother put it, " Good guys always win and Freddie always wins, even if the bad guys think they got him. There's always another movie." He has a point.

I've gotten pretty good at hiding the fact that we're poor. If a friend wants to come over then I just say my parents don't like having people over or my house is just really dirty. Eventually they'll cave and we can go over to their house, where they have really nice stuff and stuffed raviolis for dinner. Another important thing to do when you don't have any money is to brush your teeth a lot, even if you don't have toothpaste. Your teeth should look perfect. (Shows off teeth.) Smell is the strongest sense connected to

memory and if people remember you as the smelly kid, you're not going to have friends. And you can use baking soda to brush your teeth. .

My brother was always much more vocal about his concerns about money. On his last birthday he said, "This is the regular Freddie claw. I already have one. I wanted the light up sound effects claw. What do you expect me to do, run around punishing my enemies without cool lights and sound effects?!" He did already have the regular claw. He wore it to breakfast every morning. Watching him try to pick up his fork with that thing on was the highlight of my day and made the cat food bearable.

Even after my dad lost his job, he was still out looking for a job or food for us by the time my brother and I got out of school, making us both latchkey kids. I wear my key as a sort of badge of honor.

Freddy's school is right down the street from mine and we meet up, then walk the nine blocks home. So, like usual, one day a few weeks ago we met up and he was about half a block in front of me using his claw to attack everything, mostly squirrels. Since he didn't get the "light-up sound effects" glove, he provided his own sound effects. (Imitating Freddie) "Shlink! Shlink! You're dead now." The squirrels were genuinely terrified.

"Jaime." "Yeah, Freddy?" "My stomach hurts." I stopped. I could see he looked pale, I don't know why I didn't see it before. "It hurt all day, but I didn't want to say anything because they would take me to the hospital, dad's always says hospitals are expensive and that's where mom… where she…" My whole body went numb and I felt the whole world slip away around us. "I don't want to die Jaime…"

His words hit me like a punch. " That's not going to happen Freddy… what happened to mom, that was different. You should have said something!" I don't know why I was yelling. I shouldn't have been angry, it just made him cry more.

I walked with him twenty blocks to the hospital, crying and fighting all the way. The people at the front desk gave us a hard time for not having insurance and kept asking where my Dad was, but when they saw how much pain Freddy was in the doctor eventually saw him. He said that we were lucky, Freddy had Appendicitis, so they prepped him for surgery and removed his appendix.

When I met my Dad in the waiting room. He asked if Freddy was alright. I said yes and burst into tears… Something inside me had clicked. Dad didn't say anything about moneym because it didn't matter. In that moment there was just me, Freddy and my Dad. That's all there ever was, but we had been so focused on money for so long… wasting our time together… I guess I can live with eating a little cat food every now and then, as long as I can share it with my family.